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STATUE



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Written for thought, not action

Matthew 25:29

Alchemy

What's that one about?

It seems they wanted to turn everything into gold

They must not have met you

I wouldn't have helped much, I'm not very bright

It appears so



He woke to the dim, colorless light on cold ground. The air was cool against his bare skin, with not a single cloth to keep him warm. He sat up slowly, a heavy soul and an empty mind. Not a speck of dirt clung to him, not a single scent marked his body. His mind searched for familiarity. But all he was drawn to was the woman lying to his right. She rested upon a delicate wooden bed carved with slender, flowing lines.

She lay elegantly still, her body a symphony of curves and grace. Her eyes remained closed, a treasure yet to be revealed. Of all her curves, the one that caught him most was the subtle smile resting on her lips. She seemed lost in a pleasant dream that his essence refused to wake.

A statue in the room had gone unnoticed; his eyes were too lost in her beauty to see it. Then the statue's eyes flared to life, like twin lanterns in a cavern's shadow. For the first time, he saw the stone clearly. As if dormant underwater for a century, the statue was rough to the touch yet still unmistakable in form. And then the statue spoke, a soft voice that could command even the empty room it had long inhabited. The cords of an old, once-powerful man. He followed the sound as the statue emitted a deep, steady voice from still lips.

Welcome to The Tower

The Tower?

So pleasant, up is the only way

Up from where...? Where am I?

The floor you arrived, bound to its infinity

And what floor is that?

Give to The Tower, and the water will slow,

Water?

yet never stop

The statue fell silent, and for a few moments, he wondered whether it was he or the statue before his feet that had gone mad. Confusion knotted his mind as he scanned the room for a hint of reason. Then the steady pulse of light from the statue's eyes drew his attention back. The voice continued.

The Tower wants only what you want

With each step you take,

it learns to take it ever more deftly

What if I want out?

I would love to tell you but...

But what?

The larger the tide becomes,

the larger the wave gets

The words of the statue felt like smoke to him, twisting in his mind. Then, abruptly, he heard what he could only describe as a lion's roar. Not even a second later, the statue's voice broke into a piercing screech, like a dying star clawing at his ears.

THE WATER IS COMING
GIVE TO THE TOWER
AND ALL SHALL RECEIVE

The eyes of the statue darkened, and the faint light grew just enough to illuminate a door across the room. He stalled, distrusting of the light, until the roars grew louder and louder. At last, her essence pulled him closer. He lifted her gently into his shaking arms so as to not wake her ember-like smile. From then on, like moth to fire, he followed the light.

He managed to open the door before him with a single hand. His other hand kept her from the eerie floor, like the bonds that keep oil from fresh water. Beyond the door stretched a long, winding staircase he had no choice but to ascend. He climbed softly yet swiftly, as if to escape the rising tide. With The Tower's light growing stronger at each step, he scaled and scaled. Miraculously, she remained asleep in his arms, still holding onto that gentle curve.

He arrived at another door. This one looked much like the previous, yet somehow more refined. It was more welcoming, as if it had been designed just for him. He opened the door to reveal an empty room, save for a single bed placed perfectly in its center. The frame was simple yet sweet, though the floor beneath remained cold. Feather-like, he laid her on the bed. His eyes couldn't help but meander to the right. On the ground rested the very clothing he knew in his heart he truly loved. Beside what he knew was meant for him lay a dress he surely knew was meant for her.

He carefully dressed her, slipping each garment on with tender hands. Every piece of the dress fell perfectly into place, as though the dress had been waiting for her. He took great care so that, if she woke, she would be free from any embarrassment brought her way.

Her eyes opened, and he fell in love at once, simply at the sight of her dark brown gaze. It reminded him of rich earth, giving life to everything within its reach.

To guard against potential rejection, he hid his love. But just as a river is destined to flow downhill, the inevitable had happened. And so, without names, to one another, they simply became...

him, and *her*

From then on, together, they followed the light. He led as the light guided him up the helical stairs. Each staircase revealed a new room, offering its own unique, tailored experience. The light didn't shine on the next door until, at last, its inhabitants grew weary of each room's novelty. All the while, his heart remained quiet about the waves headed their way.

Occasionally, flowers sprouted from the cracks in the hard stone. She was always drawn to the beauty of life. She sought life, and he sought her; together, they sought to live. She was his joy, and in return, he gave back the little life he could find. A new color for each day they shared.

The Tower continued to give. First came a room overflowing with every type of chocolate imaginable, the taste only limited by the snug fit of their clothing. Next, a room designed to shed the pounds gained from the last. A room filled with every kind of equipment one could want to sculpt the perfect figure. But then came a room with no end, no door to be found.

Nostalgia swept over them as they faced yet another single bed sitting in the middle of an empty room. All that remained was a bedside table. On the table rested a gold-plated mirror, gleaming softly in the dim light.

are you fixing your hair again?
yeah, why not?
you don't need that mirror
how else will I see my reflection?
use my voice

you're beautiful

She set the mirror down, but her view flickered to the backside. His reflection caught her eye, gleaming as clearly as the front, silent, she pondered. Suddenly, a door materialized at the far end of the room. Holding the mirror, they pressed onward.

Outside The Tower, a loud storm began to brew, finally pulling him from his trance and back into the truth he had been hiding. The sound of hard rain hitting the glass windows reminded him of the water still in their path. He decided that, from then on, he would go ahead of her in every room. He told her it was to keep her safe, but the truth was that it was to shield her from the reality of the rising tide. He thought to himself that putting so much joy into such depravity would be like merging heaven and hell. She was his light; The Tower was his pain.

But eventually, like Icarus with the sun, he got too comfortable. In the next room, they entered together. He was confronted by it. A slightly more refined statue, identical in appearance, sat once more at the center of the room. His nerves tightened, and before he could shield her eyes, it spoke firmly.

The Tower will fall,
fate had foreseen it all
You will find ground within streams,
full of life, fulfilling old dreams
Bringing peace to the life The Tower keeps,
holding each other in sleeps
The structure will put love to the test,
a challenge to see if your hearts can rest

The statue paused, and silence grew, broken only by the furious rain punching the glass panels. His nerves intensified, but he was forced to mask them so that she wouldn't become weary. She looked at him, but before her eyes could focus, the statue spoke a second time.

Until then,
we wait as tides draw in
Your wants increase,
as your needs slowly decease
You will have to do what you do not desire,
but must be done to escape the rising fire
As it closes near,
so do The Tower's desires appear
Until it takes hold of what makes you crave,
overtake your mind, none to save

A hole opened around the statue, and in the blink of an eye, the monolith sank beneath the floor. Just as quickly, the hole closed, and the storm subsided, leaving only their thoughts to run wild.

What was that?
I don't know
This tower will fall?
How can something infinite fall?
Rising fire?
That thing must have gone mad
Sure sounds like it

They continued up The Tower as if nothing had changed. But now, they were not guided by The Tower's light, only by his fear. The fear that she might discover what he had been hiding from her all this time. As her curiosity grew, so did his worry. Yet even in the face of uncertainty, his love remained blinding.

They eventually found themselves in a room filled with every book one could ever desire to read. Its shelves stretched endlessly. She would read while he listened.

What's that book you're holding?
The Theory of Relativity
What's relativity?
A discovery, planets bend space and time,
and eventually hold mass nothing can escape
So the larger the planet becomes,
the larger the mass gets?
Exactly, how did you figure that out?
I must've heard it somewhere
Must have been a past life

He stuttered for a moment, trying to place where he had heard the words he had just uttered. But the thought grew tiresome, and, like always, he returned his focus back to her.

So the planets pull on each other?
They don't pull, silly
Forgive me, then how do they attract?
They simply follow the laws of the universe
The laws of the universe?
They follow the bends of the planets around them

Suddenly, he remembered where he had heard those haunting words before, and a shadow passed over him. An emptiness welled

up inside him, and despite his attempt to conceal it, his newly found demeanor shone through.

You aren't getting mad at planets, now are you?
How can I be mad at something I've never seen?
Life only obeys the laws they were born into
Who do you think made those laws?
Some say God, others say, well...
nothing

He pulled away, sinking into his thoughts, but the darkness of the statue's words clung to him like a parasite. Heavy and unrelenting, molding every notion in his mind.

It says that the force that attracts them,
eventually causes everything to collapse inward
Someone should stop it, that sounds evil
You think we should mess with nature?
Not mess with nature, preserve nature
But if we stop gravity, how would planets form?
How would two planets meet?

After her brain could take no more, she longed for a short rest. She decided to return to the room descending two flights of stairs. He knew the risks, but telling her not to go, would be to reveal what

he mustn't. He knew he couldn't sleep, regardless, since the statue had returned. He let her go alone, for now.

It's much easier climbing down isn't it?
Go ahead, I'll be with you soon
Be quick, It's lonely sleeping alone

They tread down the first set of stairs together, parting ways at the door to the statue's room one floor down. Hoping to find a way to make the statue disappear, he went to examine where the statue had once stood. Just as he heard her final footstep on the swirling stairs, all doors swung shut. From the center of the floor, the statue began to rise again—this time, not alone. Smooth and carved from marble, a table rose shortly after.

I am glad you sent her off
WHAT DO YOU WANT?
Only what you want
I WANT HER, NOT YOU

The statue remained emotionless, as still and silent as the water resting upon the marble table, forming a miniature pond of its own.

Answer my question correctly,
and you will be free
What question?
Look at the table
I'm looking
Notice how the water is level
Nothing is happening
Let us bring the water to life

The hard marble surface began to soften, transforming into fresh soil through which the water on top slowly seeped. The calm water remained level, yet ever so slowly was absorbed into the soil below, never to be seen again.

Notice how the water moves,
yet does not flow
Water flows by creating mountains

The table shifted once more, the soil rising and folding, until it formed a small-scale mountain range. Cracking and groaning, the mountain rose higher piercing through the once-calm water. A range full of life, crowned by a single peak, wrapped in a blanket of trees at its center. The water began racing downward. At the base, the water rested, circling in a narrow moat-like river. A few moments later, as the water dwindled, the mountain's green

crown began to fade. The summit slowly withered, from peak to trough.

How does it look?
It's dying

From the ceiling, a machine descended, releasing a soft spray of water. The droplets fell, nourishing the once-dry terrain.

What's that?
Nourishment,
powered only by the flow of water
How does flowing water generate power?
The friction it makes with the mountain

Once again, the mountain's peak began to wither. In response, the statue pushed the mountain higher and higher. The increased altitude strained for greater friction between water and stone. But as it elevated, the rivers below were drawn upward, forcing them to become part of the mountain.

As you can see, the soil is alive,
and we have flowing water

Eventually, the machine on the ceiling slowed, its steady stream of water reducing to a fine mist. Before he could see more, the statue pushed the table back underground.

Now for your question
What makes the water move?
Seriously, that's your question?
What makes the water move?
The mountain you made?
Wrong

He froze, taken aback and shocked by the statue's calm refusal to accept what he had thought to be obvious.

Just as you follow The Tower's light,
water only follows its curves
To be exact,
the curves of the structure beneath
Exactly, so it's the mountain
Wrong
Wait, The Tower's light?

Once again, he was taken aback, completely at a loss as to what the statue was babbling about. But nothing could have prepared him for the next question.

Then why not tell her?

What are you talking about?

Why not tell her about the coming tide

I LOVE HER, THAT'S WHY

You lie to those you love?

I want her to live without worry

You keep her from the truth,

because she is your escape from it

He halted, perplexed by the statement, but his thoughts quickly diverted. Too painful to explore, his mind sought to deflect.

What does this have to do with the question?

Is the water getting closer,

or are you pulling it closer?

What?

No blame for yourself?

THE WATER IS COMING

His heart stopped. He had forgotten; one floor below, she lay. In a rush of urgency, he began to plead, but all the statue offered in return was its clawing screech.

WHAT MAKES THE WATER MOVE?

Convinced of the statue's madness, he panicked, blurting out anything that might relate to the table. That is, until he grasped the last thought on his mind. He screamed as loudly as the storm brewing below him.

THE WATER

The door unlocked instantly as he jolted down the winding staircase. He could hear a faint ocean surge, boiling in the distance. The only hope was that she wouldn't wake, hearing the water's approach.

When he arrived, his worst nightmare came true. He found her at the door, about to exit. He grabbed her waist, pulling her closer. After setting her on the closest dry step he could find, they followed The Tower upward. They raced past the next room, only to hear the statue, destined to be drowned.

THE TRUTH IS REVEALED

A piercing laugh echoed behind them, and stunned by the statue's horrifying echoes, they pressed on the only way they could. They followed The Tower's light in silence. They flew past the library

and reached a room filled with dry clothes, another bed, and a letter.

Sorry for the pain we have caused
As an apology,
we offer fresh clothing,
and more rest
The Tower wants only what you want

- The Tower

They slept, but by morning, the muddy water had made her sick. They followed The Tower, and fortunately, the next room offered more.

We must apologize once more
This water is not natural
You must take this potion,
drink it to soothe your pain
The Tower wants only what you want

- The Tower

Relief washed over her as she drank the potion. She sank into the bed, savoring the first moment of true rest since the adrenaline of the rising tide.

This is YOUR FAULT
WHAT DID I DO?
YOU THINK you know better than ME?
If you knew, that's not protection is it?
Did I ask to be protected from every little thing?
I LOVE YOU
YOU THINK YOU KNOW BETTER THAN ME?
CALM DOWN
WHO IS THE ONE YELLING?

Frustrated, he climbed the following set of stairs to the next room. The room featured its first clear window. The window was expansive, its glass reaching high above, offering an unobstructed view of the outside world. All that met him was an infinite sea of water. To his right, he spotted a door radiating a light unlike any he had ever seen. The light felt like home. He heard her steps lagging behind him, as if to apologize as he approached the light. When he stepped through, he inhaled the fresh air. Beneath him, that same cold floor felt long ago. The Tower ended; the path was finite. At the center of the rooftop stood the same dreaded statue.

Only us again

YOU LIED

That makes two of us

WE ARE NOT THE SAME

It feels good at the top, does it not?

The fresh air, the view...

Voices rose from below, muffled yet unified. He couldn't make out the words, but they grew louder with each passing moment.

Who are they?

The water, as we all are

Those are cries, not waves

All water is created equal

What do they want?

What I want

What do you want?

What they want

WHAT IS THAT?

What all water seeks...

balance

He stood there, frustration ringing in his ears. His anger toward her fizzled, a dying spark drowned by the statue's words.

If I were to spare the submerged,
would you not be loud as well?
NO, I DON'T CARE
But you climbed all this way
WHAT'S YOUR POINT?
Why must I have a point?
Are you God?
I know of nothing higher than me
Even if there is, or ever was,
they are only drips on the same tower
We all find our place here,
The Tower bends us

The statue's cryptic words, he could only attribute to its madness. But then, like water disappearing into parched ground, the statue's voice faded from his mind. All he could hear now was a vicious cough rising from below, growing louder with each step competing with the screeches of the sunken. Then, it hit him.

YOU GAVE HER A CURE
WHY IS SHE STILL COUGHING?
I did not give her a cure,
I gave her what she wanted
YES, SHE WANTED A CURE
She only sought to feel better
YES, A CURE
She will only want the cure afterward,
when she realizes it was not
Unfortunately, there are no rooms left
Do not take your anger out on me,
I am only a drip on the same tower

His wrath surged as he stared into the vast abyss trying to escape what was right in front of him. The desire to destroy the statue grew like wildfire, yet he knew his flesh was no match.

I would love to congratulate you,
but if you have not noticed,
the stairs got much shorter as you climbed
Born on The Floor of Comfortability
Too distracted to see?
Must have been your lust for the girl

His thoughts drifted to her. The statue's silence eased him; its absence of screeching indicated that the water might still be a ways away.

Do you think I took her mind?
No
Here is the real question
Would she have wanted the sleep,
if first, I did not make her tired?
Would she have kept the mirror,
if I had not given it to her
She stopped asking for flowers,
as a result, you stopped giving

His wrath swelled, growing stronger with each breath. His gaze shifted from the abyss, locking onto the stone's unyielding eyes.

IT SHOULDN'T BE THIS WAY
Do not speak of what should be,
only what is
'Should' is just a stubborn illusion
WHO CREATED THIS?
You did
WHAT ARE YOU SAYING?

His mind went blank. His only thought was that he hadn't done anything. All he had ever been was born to The Tower, a fate he had never chosen.

You are lucky you got here,
before I took your mind
What would you have done with my mind
Only given you what you want
Time with her
Perhaps, perhaps not
I KNOW WHAT I WANT
I am sure you think that
I KNOW IT
Then why are you still here?
The water is coming

She ascended the stairs leading outside, already knowing what awaited. From behind his still frame, her hand caressed him. She rubbed his shoulders in slow, circular motions to calm his fury. Her skin still carried what he could only describe as magical warmth. To deny the statue any more view of what they had, they slipped to the floor below.

The voices of the submerged gained clarity, slicing through the air with their piercing babble. Her coughs worsened, but she forced herself to speak as clearly as possible.

it's getting to us

TRAITOR, TRAITOR, TRAITOR

I know

TRAITOR, TRAITOR, TRAITOR

how can they speak through the water?

TRAITOR, TRAITOR, TRAITOR

let me cover your ears

TRAITOR, TRAITOR, TRAITOR

how else will I hear?

TRAITOR, TRAITOR, TRAITOR

use my voice

you're strong

